to set off from Ludhiana at all – 'The Prince is such a fool that he has not budged an inch,' wrote his father in one of a series of apoplectic notes sent to Wade from Shikarpur.[7]

So it was that the ceremonial send-off for Lord Auckland's war took place without the presence of the man in whose name the expedition was being sent, or indeed of any of his dynasty. In lieu of the Sadozais, the Edens set off from Simla in the middle of a monsoon downpour. Emily was not at all happy to leave her beloved Himalayan retreat. 'It is impossible to describe the squalid misery of a really wet day in camp,' she complained soon after hitting the plains.

> The servants looked soaked and wretched, their cooking pots not come from the last camp, and the tents were leaking in all directions: wherever there is a seam there is a stream . . . The camels are slipping down and dying, the hackeries sticking in the rivers. And one's personal comfort! Little ditches running around each tent, with a *slosh* of mud that one invariably slips into . . . I go under an umbrella from my tent to George's, and we are carried in palanquins to the dining tent on one side, where the dinner arrives in a palanquin on the other . . .[8]

On the way they stopped in Ludhiana to meet Prince Timur, who had still failed to leave for Peshawar. 'We had an enormous dinner at Major Wade's yesterday,' wrote Fanny, 'and the city was illuminated after the native way in long lines of little lamps . . . Shuja's son came to it, and having no elephant as well as no kingdom, they sent my own particular one to fetch him.'[9] Meanwhile, Macnaghten had lost his plates and cutlery in the chaos of the move, a cause of much anxiety for one so obsessed with the finer points of etiquette. 'Great terror reigns in the camp on account of that,' reported Fanny. 'What will Shah Soojah who eats with his fingers think of Macnaghten if he does the same?'[10]

The Governor General's damp encampment was only one part of a much larger monsoon mobilisation of troops across the entire north and west of India.

In the Bombay rain, regiments were streaming from their barracks down to the beaches to be loaded on board troop transports and ferried across the stormy sea to Karachi, Thatta and other landing points around the mouth of the Indus. In the cantonments below the Delhi Ridge, the riders of the new experimental camel batteries – mobile camel-borne mortar and Congreve